American political mindset. Even as the Wall diminished as the prominent point of standoff between and among Cold War powers, its symbolic weight continued to hold a significant place in American culture. For example, during the weeks leading up to the fortieth anniversary of the end of World War II in April 1985, President Reagan announced a plan to commemorate the occasion with a visit to Bitburg, West Germany. Allied bombing in 1944 had decimated the Rhineland town near the Luxembourg border. Bitburg was transformed into a NATO airbase during the Cold War, eventually under the supervision of the U.S. Air Force. Reagan's mission would include a visit to the Bitburg airbase and a ceremony at the Bitburg Military Cemetery with West German chancellor Helmut Kohl. Reagan was to lay a wreath to honor German soldiers buried there. At first, his plans did not include ceremonies in any other allied countries or other prominent sites from the war. Upon the announcement of the trip, the fact that the Bitburg cemetery included burial plots for forty-nine Waffen-SS Nazi officers was made known to the American public. Immediately, members of Congress and prominent Jewish Americans criticized the selection of Bitburg for this commemoration, given that no former concentration camps or sites of Jewish trauma were included in Reagan's itinerary.

Reagan addressed critics at a press conference, clarifying his decision as a matter of forging further reconciliation with West Germany, one of the United States's "staunchest allies," which in the early 1980s had supported NATO efforts to station major components of its Pershing missile system throughout the country despite its own domestic "Euro Missile" protests. Reagan also mentioned the SS soldiers, whose particular combat histories became fodder for his defense of the planned trip. Reagan claimed, "Those young men are victims of Nazism … drafted into service to carry out the hateful wishes of the Nazis. They were victims, just as surely as the victims in the concentration camps."[16] Elie Wiesel, Holocaust survivor and Nobel laureate author, who happened to be visiting the White House the following day at a ceremony in which he was bestowed with a congressional medal, addressed the president directly: "May I, Mr. President, if it's possible at all, implore you to do something else, to find a way, to find another way, another site. That place, Mr. President, is not your place. Your place is with the victims of the SS."[17] Following the public outcry and Wiesel's appeal, the White House amended the president's agenda, adding the Bergen-Belsen concentration camp to his official itinerary, though the president kept his